

University of Professional Studies, Accra
Department of Communication Studies

BACS 102 / Introduction to Journalism / Week 3

News and News Values

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Presentation Outline

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What Is News?

Defining the thing we produce

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The 5 Ws and H

The questions every story must answer

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The Core News Values

What makes a story worth telling

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Novelty, Impact & Hierarchy

How the rankings keep shifting

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Who Decides What Is News?

Culture, society, and gatekeeping

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News Judgement Online

Values in a social-media world

By the end of this week, students should be able to:

- 1 Define news and explain why definitions of it keep changing.
- 2 Apply the Five Ws and H framework to structure any story.
- 3 Identify and apply the core news values to evaluate a story's worth.
- 4 Explain how the hierarchy of news values shifts with platform and audience.
- 5 Analyse how culture, ownership, and society shape what becomes news.
- 6 Exercise sound news judgement in a fast, crowded digital environment.

What is news?



Defining News

“When a dog bites a man, that is not news. But when a man bites a dog, that is news.” — attributed to John B. Bogart, 19th-century editor

Definitions

The purpose of journalism is to provide people with the information they need to be free and self-governing. News, as the product of journalism, is therefore verified, citizen-centred information and journalism's first obligation is to the truth; its first loyalty is to citizens; its essence is a discipline of verification (Kovach, & Rosenstiel, 2001)

News is what satisfies a set of evolving news values and selection criteria that determine which stories get reported. These include exclusivity, bad news, conflict, surprise, audio-visuals, shareability, entertainment, drama, follow-up, and the news organisation's own agenda. News is therefore not random but the outcome of deliberate, structured selection shaped by both journalistic judgement and digital-era conditions such as social media shareability (Harcup & O'Neill, 2017)

Defining News

Working Definition of News: It is verified, timely information about events and issues that matter to a public, gathered, selected, and presented by journalists in service of an informed citizenry.

Key words from Definitions

Timely: News is new. It concerns recent events or fresh information the public did not have.

Significant or interesting: It matters to people's lives, or it grips their attention, ideally both.

Reaches an audience: Information becomes news only when it is gathered, verified, and shared with the public.

About the unusual: The expected rarely makes news; the unexpected, the deviant, and the consequential do.

The Five Ws and H



The skeleton beneath every news story

The Questions Every Story Must Answer

Master these and you can report anything



Who?

Who is involved? Who is affected? Who is responsible? Always name accurately and verify spelling.



What?

What happened? Get the central fact right before anything else, this is your story's spine.



When?

When did it happen? Time anchors a story and signals how fresh and urgent it is.



Where?

Where did it occur? Location drives proximity, a key reason readers care at all.



Why?

Why did it happen? Cause and motive turn an event into understanding.



How?

How did it unfold? Process and context give the audience the full picture.

The Core News Values



The filters editors use, often without naming them

News Values

Why some events become front-page and others vanish



Timeliness

The fresher the event, the stronger the news. Yesterday's scoop is today's old news.



Proximity

Events close to home matter more. A flood in Accra outranks a flood far abroad.



Prominence

Famous and powerful people make news for actions ordinary people never would.



Consequence

The more people an event affects a tax, a strike, a policy, the bigger the story.



Conflict

Disputes, contests, and clashes draw attention. Elections and courts are built on it.



Human Interest

Stories that stir emotion such as courage, loss, triumph etc connect on a human level.

News Values

Novelty

The strange, the first, the record-breaking. 'Man bites dog' endures because the unusual is irresistible.

Impact / Magnitude

Scale matters and the numbers also matters, i.e the number of deaths, cedis lost, people displaced etc , makes its newsworthy.

Relevance

Does it touch the audience's daily life? A fuel-price change beats a distant diplomatic shuffle.

Shareability

Online, a value of its own: will people pass it on? Emotion and surprise drive the share button.

A Shifting Hierarchy

The same facts, ranked differently by every newsroom

How the hierarchy changes

Two outlets, one event, different front pages

A new national budget is announced. Watch how the same story is valued differently.

A Business Newspaper

Leads with: tax changes, deficit targets, and currency implications.

Top values: consequence and impact for investors and firms.

The human-interest angle is minor; the numbers are the news.

A Community Radio Station

Leads with: the new price of fuel, transport fares, and school fees.

Top values: proximity and relevance to listeners' daily survival.

The macro-economics matter less than what changes at the market tomorrow.

News values are not fixed. Audience, platform, and purpose reshuffle the hierarchy every day.

Who decides what is news?

Gatekeeping, culture, and the limits of objectivity

Forces that shape news selection

The story you see is the product of many choices



Gatekeeping

Editors choose what to run and what to drop. Every front page is a series of human decisions.



Ownership

Who owns the outlet influences what gets covered and what gets quietly ignored.



Commercial Pressure

Ratings and clicks tempt newsrooms toward the sensational over the significant.



Culture & Values

What counts as 'newsworthy' differs across societies, religions, and communities.



Sources & Access

Powerful sources shape agendas. Stories with available, willing sources rise to the top.



Audience Expectation

Newsrooms learn what their audience wants and that quietly steers future coverage.

News judgement online

Old values meet the speed and chaos of the feed

Exercising Judgement in the Digital Age

The values still apply online but the environment makes them harder to honour.

Speed pressures accuracy. The race to publish first can override the duty to verify. Resist it.

Virality is not value. A story spreading fast is not the same as a story that matters. Don't confuse the two.

Algorithms become editors. Platforms decide what audiences see, often rewarding outrage over importance.

Engagement can mislead. Clicks reward the sensational; sound judgement protects the significant and the true.

The audience now selects too. Readers share, filter, and amplify. News judgement is no longer the newsroom's alone.

Class Discussion

Think. Discuss. Disagree.

In groups of 3–4, spend 10 minutes. One person reports back to the class.

Q1

Pick a story trending on your feed today or from your newspaper. Which news values explain why it has spread or gone viral?

Q2

A celebrity wedding and a quiet change to health policy compete for the front page. Which leads, and why?

Q3

Does 'proximity' make Ghanaian newsrooms under-cover the rest of Africa? Is that a problem?

Q4

If algorithms now decide what we see, who is really the gatekeeper today, the editor or the platform?

Key Takeaways from Week 3

News is the new, the unusual, the consequential. If it is expected and affects no one, it is rarely news.

The 5 Ws and H are your skeleton. Answer them and you have a complete, reportable story.

News values are filters, not formulas. Timeliness, proximity, prominence, consequence, conflict, and human interest do the sorting.

The hierarchy is never fixed. Audience and platform decide which value wins on any given day.

Selection is a human choice. Gatekeeping, ownership, and culture shape what becomes news — be aware of the lens.

Online, judgement matters more, not less. Virality is not value. Verify before you amplify.

Any questions or comments?

Thank you.